NON-BLOOD SPECIMEN COLLECTION

Introduction

As a phlebotomist, you may also be asked to perform different types of tests due to patient needs or testing requirements. In this lesson, you will learn the steps to perform a variety of nonblood tests. Some test results need to be available sooner than would be possible when waiting for a laboratory to provide results. These tests, called point-of-care tests, have results that are available in a shorter period of time than waiting for laboratory results.

You will learn the steps to perform point-of-care tests and be made aware of when it is appropriate to perform these types of tests. You will be able to determine which supplies, preparation, and steps are necessary to perform special types of tests. This lesson is a combination of the skills you have learned for performing dermal punctures and venipuncture tests. You will also learn the steps to collect a urine sample for a variety of tests. Besides learning these procedures, you will also learn how to prepare documentation that is specific to certain types of collections.

Performing Non-Blood Tests

Some tests to help determine the status of a patient rely on bodily fluids other than blood. A phlebotomist may be called upon to perform these tests. Much of what you have learned thus far is helpful when considering these test procedures. Like when collecting blood, it is important to review the requisition to determine the supplies that you need to gather. When gathering supplies, confirm that they are unopened and unexpired. Confirm that you know which results can be shared with the patient. Remember to always wear all PPE recommended by your facility when collecting, testing, or handling any bodily fluids.

Throat Cultures

Throat cultures are ordered by the provider when a patient is ill and it is important to determine the type of disease. They may be used to confirm and identify a patient's illness. A sample is taken from the throat with a swab and is sent to the laboratory for testing.

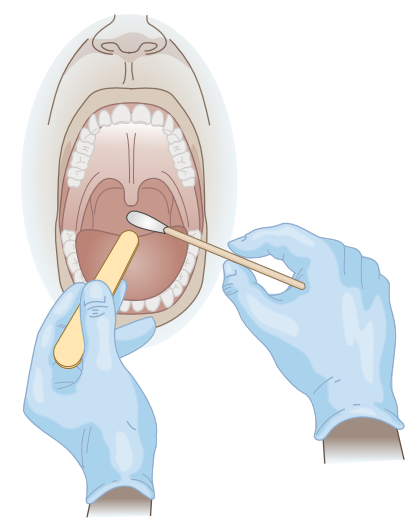
Supplies:

- Tissues
- Sample collection container
- Transport medium
- Pen
- Label
- Requisition
- PPE
- Flashlight

Performing a Throat Culture Test

1. Review the requisition, confirming that all of the necessary information has been filled in legibly.
2. Gather all necessary supplies, confirming that they are not expired or opened.
3. Wash hands.
4. Don all required PPE.
5. Introduce yourself to the patient.
6. Properly identify the patient using at least two methods of identification.
7. Inform the patient of the procedure steps.
8. Hand them tissues to use after the collection is completed (to wipe their mouth).
9. Aim the light in order to see the throat and surrounding area.
10. Seat or place the patient with their head leaned back.
11. Open swab and remove from packaging.
12. Ask the patient to open their mouth.
13. Standing to the side of the patient, use the tongue depressor to hold down their tongue.
14. Insert the swab into their throat.
15. Swab the entire surface of the throat, including the tonsils and any red areas.

Throat Swab



16. Place the swab into the transport medium.
17. Seal the container and label.
18. Compare the label to the patient's wristband and requisition.
19. Inform the patient that the test is over and that they can wipe their mouth to remove any extra mucus.
20. Transport the sample to the laboratory.

Nasal Swab

Another test that helps determine a person's condition is a nasal swab. Just like in a throat swab, secretions are collected to be tested for the patient's disease status. Also, like with a throat culture, you should wear all necessary PPE to help prevent cross contamination. When gathering supplies, confirm that none are expired and that the swab and collection container's packaging are both unopened. When performing a nasal swab on a highly contagious patient, it may be necessary to also use an N95 respirator and other PPE, including a face shield, mask, and gown. Always confirm the facility's PPE requirements for performing this type of testing.

Supplies

- Requisition
- Transport container
- Pen
- Sealed swab
- Label
- PPE
- Tissues

Nasal Swab Steps

1. Review the requisition to confirm that you will gather the correct supplies.
2. Wash hands and don all required PPE.
3. Gather supplies, confirming that they are unopened and unexpired.
4. Introduce yourself to the patient.
5. Properly identify the patient using at least two methods of identification.
6. Explain what the procedure entails, adding that it is expected that their eyes may tear up.

7. Position the patient with their head slightly back.
8. Open the swab carefully to avoid cross contamination. Do not touch the end of the swab.
9. Insert the swab until at least 1.27 cm (0.5 in) is in the nostril.
10. Roll the swab inside of the nostril for 15 seconds.
11. Repeat with the other nostril.
12. When the collection is complete, hand the patient a tissue to wipe their nose.
13. Break off the end of the swab and place it into the transport tube.
14. Label the transport container and prepare for transport.
15. Thank the patient and transport the sample.

If you are performing a test that will yield test results on the site, record the results as soon as they are made available. Inform the patient of the results only when your facility allows the sharing of results.

Wound Cultures

Occasionally, there may be concerns that a patient's wound, either from an accident or from surgery, is infected. When this concern arises, the ordering provider may decide to gather a sample from the wound area to determine if the wound is infected. Since this test is looking for bacteria, it is important to avoid cross contamination by only using unexpired supplies and by performing the test as aseptically as possible. Always wear all recommended PPE when performing this procedure.

Supplies

- All required PPE
- Wound culture swap
- Transport container
- Label
- Pen
- Bandaging supplies

Wound Culture Steps

1. Review the requisition to determine if there are any special supplies or steps required.
2. Gather supplies, confirming that they are not expired, opened, or have rips or tears in their packages.
3. Wash hands and don all required PPE.
4. Introduce yourself to the patient.
5. Tell the patient what they can expect from the test.
6. Assemble the supplies.
7. Identify the area to be sampled.
8. Remove the bandage when necessary.
9. Open the swab, being careful to avoid touching the end.
10. Swab the wound area, confirming that you have gathered an adequate sample.
11. Place the sample into the transport container.
12. Label the transport container.
13. Bandage the wound when required.
14. Confirm that the label matches the patient's information.
15. Thank the patient.
16. Transport the sample to the laboratory for testing.